



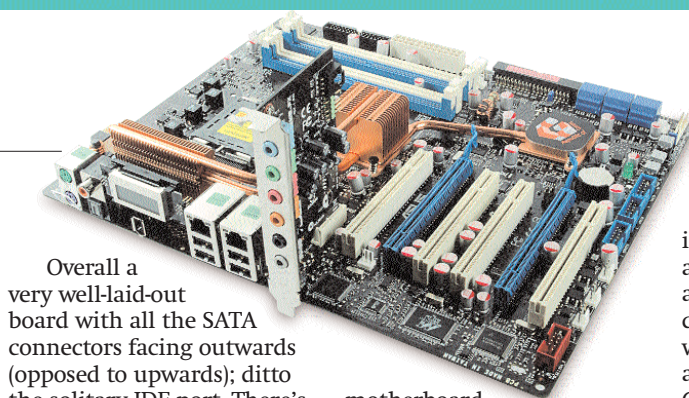
ASUS Commando ASUS goes big Arnie!

The Commando is a P965-based board that joins the "Republic of Gamers" league, consisting of the Striker (nForce 680i based), and the Crosshair (nForce 590SLI based) motherboards.

The first evident difference between the Commando and the P5B-Deluxe is the fancy heatpipe solution. Secondly, the newcomer features an all-solid state capacitor design, improving the board's life. The all-practical E-SATA back port gets dumped for the LCD diagnostic poster.

RATINGS

Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



Overall a very well-laid-out board with all the SATA connectors facing outwards (opposed to upwards); ditto the solitary IDE port. There's space aplenty between the CPU heatsink and memory modules. However, the heatpipe solution will make installation of larger heatsinks a little difficult if not impossible. Incidentally,

motherboard temperatures remained well within acceptable limits during our tests. Neither did the heatpipe assembly get too warm.

ASUS provides a plethora of overclocking and tweaking options in the BIOS. You can store various BIOS settings as Overclock Profiles, and load them at startup, depending what you plan to do during the session.

ASUS COMMANDO	
PC Mark 2005 (CPU)	5968
PC Mark 2005 (Memory)	5708
PC Mark 2005 (Graphics)	10558
PC Mark 2005 (Overall)	6180
3D Mark 2005 (GPU)	15762
3D Mark 2005 (CPU)	8700
F.E.A.R 1024x768 (4x AA, 4x AF)	147 fps
F.E.A.R 1600x1200 (4x AA, 8x AF)	80 fps

Surprisingly, the Commando lagged slightly behind the ASUS P5B-Deluxe we tested a while ago. Priced at Rs 17,500 the Commando is a bit overpriced. After all, aside from the bling factor, and the solid capacitors, it is costlier than the P5B-Deluxe, which adds Wi-Fi and E-SATA as connectivity options. Gamers will also note the full version of GRAW that's been bundled "free" with the board.

Specifications

Intel P965 chipset based; ICH8R Southbridge; 6xSATA 2 ports; Expansion slots—1xPCI-Express x16, 1xPCI-Express x4, 1xPCI-Express x1, 4xPCI slots; 4 rear USB ports; 1 FireWire port

Contact: ASUS Technology Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 022-40058923
E-mail: mamta.bhatia@asus.com
Web site: <http://in.asus.com>
Price: Rs. 17,500

Buffalo DriveStation Duo This buffalo ain't that fast

The Buffalo DriveStation Duo is an extremely well-built external drive, housed in a tough black polymer casing that looks good. Alas, it is a bit heavy at 2.9 Kg.

Internally, it has two 250 GB SATA hard drives, 7200 rpm. The drives can be configured to work in three different modes: RAID 1 (250 GB with Reliability), Full Capacity Spanning (appearing as a single 500 GB drive for Maximum Storage), and also Normal mode (Default), where you are able to use the two hard drives independently (appearing as two separate 250 GB drives). A Windows-based utility lets you configure these modes. A little indicator at the front displays the power and individual activity status.

The Duo supports both USB and FireWire400, and there are two types of FireWire connectors—4-pin and 6-pin. You can daisy-chain more such units, but the physical design of the unit is not such that you can stack these one over another. FireWire800 is lacking.

The performance of the drive is not stellar by any standards, and it was, in fact, one of the slower ones in its category. It took 55 seconds for a 1 GB file to copy to the drive; a GB of assorted data took 69 seconds.

The Memeo Backup software that accompanies the drive is versatile, and can automatically back up your files and folders to a wide variety of destinations such as hard disk, removable drive, FTP server, Network Places, iPod, and

Memeo Internet Disk (a service provided by Tanagra Inc. for Memeo Backup users, where you can back up data to a secure, private area on their servers). Secure Lock Ware is the other bundled application, which uses 256-bit AES encryption to encrypt your data.

The Duo lacks appeal for system administrators who need to take frequent backups, because of its slow performance, but the appropriate price and the software bundle seem to save its day—just about.



Specifications

500 GB (2x250 GB SATA); 7200 rpm; Seek time: 11 ms; Interface: USB 2.0, IEEE1394a (4-pin and 6-pin); software: Memeo Backup, Secure Lock Ware; Dimensions: 221 mm (H) x 163 mm (D) x 99 mm (W); weight: 2.9 kg

Contact: Advent Infotech Pvt. Ltd.
Phone: 011-41436752
E-mail: anjan@adventelectronics.com
Web site: www.buffalo-asia.com
Price: Rs. 19,999/-

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★